Research Statement

Communication, Classical Indic Philosophy, and Human Judgment in the Age of AI

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October 2026

1. Research Orientation

My research examines how changes in communication and technology affect human attention, judgment, and ethical responsibility. I approach these questions through communication theory and classical Indic philosophy, two areas of inquiry that have increasingly come together in my work.

My professional background, more than two decades in strategic communications across academic, nonprofit, and international settings, including a fellowship with the United Nations Division for Ocean Affairs and Law of the Sea, shaped this interest well before it became an academic project. Deciding what an audience needed to know, what context mattered, and when something was ready to be shared are practical versions of the same questions of judgment I now study as a scholar.

2. Foundations in Communication and Media Ethics

My scholarly foundation is in communication and media ethics, where my work asks how mediated environments shape attention, recognition, and judgment, and what responsibility communicators and institutions bear for those effects. This work has received the International Communication Association's Best Paper Award and the Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication's Carol Burnett Award.

One current strand develops the Advaita and Spanda Communication Model, a non-dual framework for studying what I call digital resonance: how recognition and genuine exchange occur, or fail to occur, in online discourse. I am applying this framework to a developing corpus of public discourse on AI and higher education, treating patterns such as adversarial exchange, partial recognition, and more transformative shifts in understanding as illustrative cases rather than settled findings.

A related strand, developed under the name Sattva-Based Cognitive Alignment Theory and now being prepared as a journal article, asks a narrower question: under what conditions is a person's competence to judge actually exercised, rather than merely available in principle, within a mediated environment. In both projects, I bring classical Indic philosophical concepts into conversation with established questions in communication theory.

3. Classical Indic Philosophy and Comparative Inquiry

My engagement with classical Indic philosophy is grounded in sustained reading of primary texts and their interpretive traditions, drawing on the Bhagavad Gītā, the Bhāgavata Purāṇa, Nyāya epistemology, Sāṃkhya, Yoga, and the non-dual traditions associated with Kashmir Śaivism. My familiarity with the Bhāgavata Purāṇa goes back to childhood, carried through family and community long before it became an object of scholarly attention; my closer textual engagement with other classical sources has developed more recently, alongside my academic research.

I begin by examining classical concepts within their textual and philosophical settings before considering whether, and in what limited sense, they can illuminate contemporary questions. I do not treat ancient texts as having anticipated modern technology, psychology, or media. Where a classical term carries a deeper soteriological meaning, concerned with liberation rather than with a practical judgment, I say so explicitly rather than letting the richer meaning stand in silently for the narrower one.

A current paper, submitted for journal review, “Reverence and Asymmetry: Dhog, Gender, and Relational Authority in Hindu Nepal,” examines dhog, a practice of embodied reverence, through Dharma literature, Purāṇic sources, and Nepalese ethnography, asking what the practice reveals about gender, kinship, and relational authority in lived Hindu Nepal.

4. Human Judgment and Responsible AI Delegation

One major current direction brings these foundations to bear on a contemporary problem: what happens to human judgment as increasingly complex cognitive work, summarizing, comparing, drafting, recommending, is delegated to generative AI. My concern is not whether AI will become autonomous or conscious. It is with the human side of delegation: capability alone does not settle what should be delegated, how far delegation should go, or when an earlier decision to delegate should be reconsidered.

I use the term Delegated Momentum, provisionally, for the tendency of authorized machine-mediated activity to continue under an earlier instruction even after conditions have changed enough that a human should pause and judge again. This can happen when a system is working exactly as intended; it does not require malfunction or autonomy. The question it raises is not only what to delegate, but how a person remains capable of governing what has already been delegated.

Sāṃkhya's distinction between prakṛti, the domain of activity and transformation, and puruṣa, consciousness itself, lets me ask what happens when human intention is carried forward through increasingly sophisticated machine-mediated activity, without first having to resolve the disputed question of machine consciousness. In Sāṃkhya, buddhi is the faculty of determination within prakṛti, while consciousness is distinguished from the cognitive processes through which judgments arise. Yoga's treatment of viveka, discriminative awareness, gives me a vocabulary for the human capacity that this delegation puts under pressure. I use the term narrowly, for a capacity to distinguish clearly in practical judgment; within Yoga's own path it carries a fuller soteriological sense, concerned with liberation, that I am not claiming for it here. I develop this argument at greater length in a conference paper presented at the World Congress on Logic and Religion, and in an ongoing book manuscript, Sattva Intelligence: A Dharmic Ethics Framework for Human Alignment and Responsible AI Delegation, currently in development.

5. Current Research Directions and Applications

My work on AI delegation is moving toward a practical question: what discernment and restraint would need to look like in an actual institutional setting. Journalism is where I expect to pursue this, since newsroom judgments about attention, sourcing, and verification cannot be reduced to factual accuracy, and they are increasingly shaped by AI-mediated workflows; I see this as a direction for future research rather than a study already under way. The Advaita and Spanda Communication Model is moving from illustrative patterns in AI and higher education discourse toward a more

systematic account of when digital exchange produces genuine recognition, and the Sattva-Based Cognitive Alignment Theory is moving from a philosophical argument toward a framework that can also be examined empirically.

My research on dhog in Hindu Nepal continues alongside this work, asking what embodied practices of reverence reveal about gender and authority in a living tradition. Alongside this academic work, I also produce public-facing research and educational material, including essays and recorded talks, that bring these questions to broader audiences.

6. The Larger Intellectual Question

Across these projects, I remain interested in the conditions under which human beings can exercise responsible judgment. Changes in communication technologies make this question increasingly urgent, but it is not a new question. Classical philosophical traditions offer ways of examining attention, cognition, restraint, and responsibility that remain valuable when approached in their own historical and conceptual settings. My research seeks to develop these connections without reducing the differences between the traditions and disciplines involved.

This is the work I expect to keep developing, across further papers and the book manuscript now in progress.